



SHORT-VOWEL CVC BINDER

Read it · Build it · Write it — a no-prep intervention binder for beginning and struggling readers.

Grades K–2

No prep

Print & reuse

Data sheets

5

short-vowel
units

30

practice
pages

5

probes +
data sheets

2

AI Growth
Eval pages



Ends with an **AI Growth Eval** — turn the scores you collected into this week's next three moves.



Print once, reuse

Sleeve it, hand out a dry-erase marker, use it all year.



Sequence printed inside

So you can slot it into the program you already teach.



Cited, not guessed

The research behind it is named on the last page.





SHORT A

cat • map • sad • pan • bag • hat

Consonant–vowel–consonant. No blends, no digraphs.

The sequence in this binder

1 • short a

2 • short i

3 • short o

4 • short u

5 • short e

6 • mixed review

How to use this unit

Print the practice pages once and slide them into sleeves — students write with a dry-erase marker and the binder lasts all year. Teach the unit, practice daily, then give the ten-word probe on the data sheet. Take the score to the Growth Eval page and it tells you whether to hold or move.

Why the sequence is printed here

So you can slot this into whatever phonics program you already use instead of guessing what it assumes. Short **a** comes first because it is the most common short vowel in early decodable words, and **e** comes last because **e** and **i** are the pair students most often confuse — separating them reduces that collision. Every word in this unit is a true CVC word: one consonant, one short vowel, one consonant.

Structure follows the IES practice guide's two strong-evidence recommendations for K–3: link speech sounds to letters, and teach students to decode, write, and recognize words. Full citation on the last page.

READ IT. BUILD IT. WRITE IT.

Say the word out loud. Push a letter into each box. Then write it on the line.

READ

BUILD

WRITE



cat

o

o

o

.....



map

o

o

o

.....



sad

o

o

o

.....



pan

o

o

o

.....



bag

o

o

o

.....



hat

o

o

o

.....



Challenge: pick two words and say a whole sentence for each, out loud.

Colour a star for each word you read on your own



Teacher tally

 / 6

UNIT 1 PROBE • DATA SHEET

Ten words, read aloud, once a week. Circle each one read correctly. Score out of 10 — then take the score to the Growth Eval.

Probe word	Week 1	Week 2	Week 3	Week 4
cat	☐	☐	☐	☐
map	☐	☐	☐	☐
sad	☐	☐	☐	☐
pan	☐	☐	☐	☐
bag	☐	☐	☐	☐
hat	☐	☐	☐	☐
tap	☐	☐	☐	☐
rag	☐	☐	☐	☐
jam	☐	☐	☐	☐
van	☐	☐	☐	☐
Score / 10				

What did you notice? (the eval page uses this)

Which sound slipped · speed or accuracy · did the miss change week to week · did they self-correct

Move-on signal: 8 of 10 across two probes in a row. Mastery criteria in phonics research commonly sit at 80–90% accuracy; we use 80% twice rather than 90% once, so a single good day doesn't look like mastery.

AI GROWTH EVAL • one STUDENT

Find the score from the data sheet. Read across. No technology needed for any of this.

0-4

The sound isn't secure yet.

- Drop back to letter-sound work with just **a** — three minutes daily.
- Use two-sound words (at, am) before three-sound words.
- Re-probe in one week with the same ten words.

5-7

Blending is emerging but not automatic.

- Stay in the unit and keep the Build-It step — don't skip to writing.
- Time one page: if accuracy is fine, the gap is speed, not the sound.
- Re-probe in one week; move at 8 twice in a row.

8-10

Short a is solid. Move.

- Start Unit 2 (short i); keep short a alive in mixed review.
- Spot-check short a again in three weeks.

OPTIONAL • IF YOU USE AN AI ASSISTANT

"I teach 2nd grade. A student scored 6 out of 10 on a short-vowel CVC probe. The misses were all words ending in -g and -m, and they self-corrected twice. Give me three specific next steps for this week and one way to check whether it worked."

Describe the grade and the pattern — never a name, never a class list. The student never uses the tool.

Honest limits: ten words is a signal, not a diagnosis. Use it to choose this week's move, alongside everything else you know about the reader.

GROUP SNAPSHOT • WHO NEEDS WHAT

Record the group by student number — S1, S2, S3 — not by name. The pattern across the group tells you how to split your minutes next week — that is the decision this page exists to make.

Student	Score /10	Which words missed	Group
1.	---	-----	---
2.	---	-----	---
3.	---	-----	---
4.	---	-----	---
5.	---	-----	---
6.	---	-----	---

Re-TEACH

0–4 • daily sound work

PRACTISE

5–7 • stay in unit

Move on

8–10 twice • next unit

OPTIONAL • LET AI DO THE SORTING

"Here are short-vowel CVC probe scores for a 2nd-grade group, out of 10, with the words each one missed. S1: 6 (bag, rag, jam, van). S2: 9 (jam). S3: 7 (bag, rag, jam). S4: 6 (rag, jam, bag, van). S5: 9 (rag). S6: 4 (bag, rag, jam, van, sad, hat). Group them into re-teach / practise / move on, tell me the sound pattern most of the group is missing, and suggest how to split 20 minutes of small-group time across the three groups tomorrow."

Student numbers only — S1, S2, S3. No names, no initials, nothing about the child beyond the score and the words missed.

Why this works: the words each student missed carry more information than the score. In the example above, five of six students read cat, map, pan, sad, hat and tap correctly and missed bag, rag or jam — the vowel is the same in every one of those words, so the short a is not the problem. The final sounds -g and -m are. That is a fifteen-minute lesson, not a re-teach of the whole unit.

HOW THIS BINDER IS BUILT

What we based it on, what we are claiming, and what we are not.

The instructional structure

Each unit links speech sounds to letters and then asks the student to decode, build, and write the same words. That mirrors the two **strong-evidence** recommendations in the IES/What Works Clearinghouse practice guide for K–3 foundational skills: *"Develop awareness of the segments of sounds in speech and how they link to letters"* and *"Teach students to decode words, analyze word parts, and write and recognize words."*

The 8-of-10 move-on signal

Mastery criteria in phonics commonly sit between 80% and 100% accuracy, with 90% often cited. We ask for 80% on two consecutive probes rather than 90% once, because repeating the criterion is what separates a good day from a secure skill. Adjust it to match whatever your school already uses — the data sheet works either way.

What we are not claiming

This binder is not aligned to, affiliated with, or a substitute for any named phonics program, and it is not a diagnostic assessment. It is practice material and a ten-word progress check. Every word in Unit 1 is a true short-a CVC word — one consonant, one short vowel, one consonant — with no blends or digraphs, so the probe measures the one thing it says it measures.

References

Foorman, B., Beyler, N., Borradaile, K., Coyne, M., Denton, C. A., Dimino, J., Furgeson, J., Hayes, L., Henke, J., Justice, L., Keating, B., Lewis, W., Sattar, S., Streke, A., Wagner, R., & Wissel, S. (2016). *Foundational skills to support reading for understanding in kindergarten through 3rd grade* (NCEE 2016-4008). National Center for Education Evaluation and Regional Assistance, Institute of Education Sciences, U.S. Department of Education. Revised December 2019.

Phonics Hero. *Mastery in phonics learning*. — summary of criterion levels used in phonics research (80–100%, with 90% most commonly cited).

Built and audited by two certified teachers. If you find an error in any word list or probe, email us through TPT and we will fix it and re-upload the same day — you keep the updated file free.